

a 300mAh lithium-ion polymer battery that provides playback for up to ten hours. High-end products pack battery capacity of around 600mAh, allowing a run-time of 20 hours or more. The built-in battery can be charged by a standard mini or micro-USB cable. It takes three to four hours to fully replenish the battery.

aptX support. aptX is an up-graded codec, presently owned by Qualcomm, which enhances the audio quality via a bitrate efficiency algorithm—providing enhanced sound quality through Bluetooth. The prerequisite is that both the source device and the audio equipment must have aptX to utilise the feature.

Presently, most of the popular audio equipment and Android smartphones and devices support and have aptX built into them. Android devices without aptX can also be upgraded. MAC and Windows equipment may also be aptX-compatible, depending on their hardware. A higher upgrade, called aptX HD, is also out there, which provides even better audio quality than CD-scale. However, the number of devices supporting aptX HD is limited presently.

Noise cancellation. Headphones with noise-cancellation capability have built-in microphones and electronic chips that record the ambient noise and create anti-phase sound waves (same amplitude but completely inverse phase) accordingly, which cancel out the original noise. This is very effective against low-frequency noise. High-frequency noise, however, is not controlled much by this technique.

Usually, noise-cancellation capability varies within products based on the quality of components. If tested separately, it can be measured by the amount of decibels that is decreased for a given frequency of sound. The performance completely depends on the value of the sound frequency. For example, a headphone that claims to drop 30dB sound may be doing so at 60Hz but might cancel only 10dB at 480Hz, and so on.

Indian market: Latest offerings

The Indian market has a substantial range of wireless headphones for buyers to select from. Wireless headphones cost more than their wired counterparts, but provide unparalleled sound experience.

High-end products. The latest offering from the stable of Bose, QuietComfort 35, costs around ₹ 30,000. Featuring the company's innovative noise-cancellation technology and 20 hours of battery life, these headphones are wrapped in a polyester-based sophisticated covering material, corrosion-resistant stainless steel, glass-filled nylon and impact-resistant materials.

Momentum Wireless Over-Ear by Sennheiser costs around ₹ 35,000. It features NFC and Bluetooth connectivity with aptX support, NoiseGuard active noise-cancellation technology and hands-free Voice Max microphone, making it very easy to use.

Mid-range products. In the medium price range, Plantronics has introduced models like BackBeat Pro 2, BackBeat Go 3 and BackBeat Fit to suit diverse application areas like sports, work and travel. These headphones cost between ₹ 6000 and ₹ 11,000.

Another player, Jaybird, Logitech-owned sports headphone specialist, has come up with the Jaybird X3 that features passive noise-isolation technology, sweat-proof built with X-Fit System, and in-line remote. It costs between ₹ 13,000 and ₹ 19,000.

Low-end products. Wireless headphones in this segment are priced between ₹ 1000 and ₹ 5000. Companies like Zebronic, Philips, Skullcandy and Sportszee are producing and delivering quality wireless headphones keeping the consumers' price limitations in mind. You can also find an array of base-range headphones from other players, like LG Tone+ HBS 730, Nokia BH 505 and Jabra Halo Smart. **BY**

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